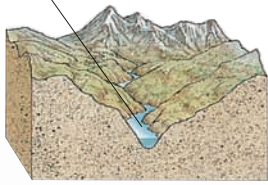


This is a river valley before the arrival of a glacier. Glaciers are huge masses of ice that grind away land as they move slowly forward.



THE LAKE DISTRICT

The 15 lakes of the Lake District in northwestern England lie in U-shaped valleys extending outward like the spokes of a wheel from an uplifted dome of low mountains. Long ago, the valleys contained rivers, but during the Ice Age these were deepened by the movement of glaciers. Most were dammed by eroded rock left behind when the glaciers melted. The erosion of the main valleys has cut off tributary valleys and left them “hanging” above the main valleys, often with waterfalls cascading from them.



When glaciers retreat, at the end of an Ice Age for example, they leave behind U-shaped valleys.

A hanging valley on the side of the main valley

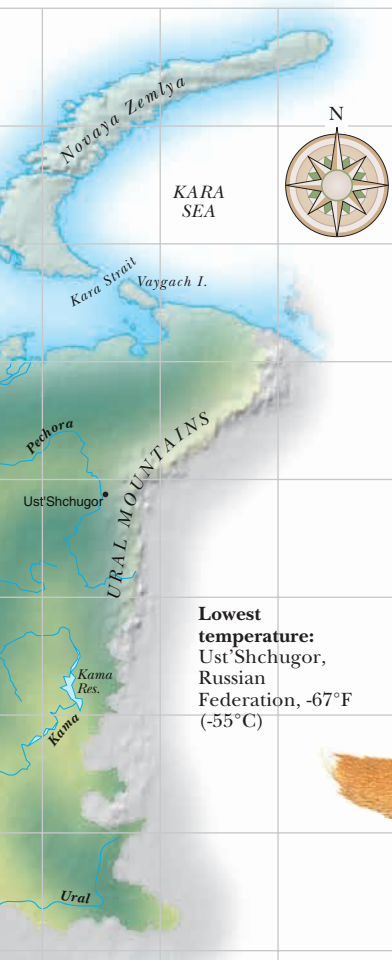


Ullswater is a lake that lies in a U-shaped valley.



NORTHERN FORESTS

A thick band of dense coniferous forest, known as taiga, covers northern Europe. Conifers (trees that have cones), such as spruce and pine, keep their leaves all year round and can withstand heavy snow. They also provide winter food and shelter for many animals.



Lowest temperature:
Ust'Shchugor,
Russian Federation, -67°F
(-55°C)

NORTHERN PLAINS

The North European Plain stretches from southern England across France and Germany as far as Russia, ending at the Ural Mountains. Most of the plain is low-lying, and in the Netherlands it even lies partly below sea level. Some of the world's most fertile farmland is found here, as well as important deposits of coal, oil, and natural gas. This is Europe's most densely populated area and contains many major cities.



Wheat, sugar beets, and apples are grown on the plains of northern France.



Foxes are often found in the fields and woodlands of Europe, although many now live in towns. They eat almost anything – from rabbits to apples or worms.

THINGS TO LOOK FOR ON THE MAP

Area: 4,000,000, sq miles
(10,400,000 sq km)

Highest point: Mt. El'brus,
Russian Federation, 18,510 ft
(5,642 m) *Map K11*

Longest river: Volga, Russian Federation, 2,194 miles
(3,530 km) *Map L8*

Largest lake: L. Ladoga,
Russian Federation,
7,100 sq miles (18,389 sq km)
Map J7

Largest island: Great Britain,
88,745 sq miles
(229,850 sq km) *Map D9*

THE MEDITERRANEAN

The region around the Mediterranean Sea has a distinctive climate of hot, dry summers and mild, rainy winters. These conditions are perfect for growing crops such as citrus fruits, grapes, and olives, shown here in southern Spain. Many trees, such as cork oaks, develop thick bark as a protection against the heat.



THE DANUBE

The Danube, western Europe's longest river, flows eastward from its source in Germany to its mouth on the Black Sea. It serves as a trade route between the nine countries that lie along its course. The Danube delta, where the river divides into numerous channels, is an important wetland area. About 300 different bird species have been recorded in the delta, as well as boars, deer, and wild cats.